of five mountain ranges separating the Yangzi river basin from the southern Pearl River basin and delta. Northern Vietnam was conquered in 111 BCE and ruled as the Jiaozhi province thereafter for over 1,000 years, with brief interruptions.

While direct Chinese rule ended in the eleventh century, the rulers of Vietnam continued to acknowledge their vassal status. This long period of Chinese rule and continued political relationship meant that the people of Vietnam were greatly influenced by Chinese political thought, governance, social and moral codes, culture and art. Buddhism, however, did not play an important role as a vehicle for transmission of Chinese culture to Vietnam. During their period of rule, the Han Chinese forced the adoption of what they considered superior Chinese culture over the Vietnamese people, who were considered less civilized. This was true of Chinese attitudes towards the peoples of Guangdong and Guangxi, too, and these attitudes persist into modern times. When I was studying Mandarin in Hong Kong in the 1970s, my teachers, who were from the north, would forbid language students from learning even a few words of the local Cantonese dialect, describing it as the language of the ‘Nan Man’, or southern barbarians.

Like Korea and Japan, Vietnam also adopted the Han script, the ‘Chu Han’. It was used together with another script called ‘Chu Nom’, which derived from the Han script but which could better reflect the sounds of Vietnamese. This is similar to what we see in Japan and Korea. In Japan, the Han script was adopted by the sixth century CE and was known as ‘Kanji’. Korea played an important role in the transmission of Chinese culture to Japan, and this included introduction of the Chinese script. However, later in Japan, this borrowed script was combined with a supplementary phonetic set of symbols based on the Sanskrit syllabary (or written symbols representing syllables). The syllabary was brought to Japan by the Japanese monk-scholar Kobo Daishi in the eighth century from China, where he had the opportunity to study Sanskrit from an Indian master. This was the Kana phonetic alphabet, based on the Siddham script, which evolved from the ancient Brahmi script in which Sanskrit was written. The Kana alphabet was later developed into the Hiragana and